

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 223

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9 SANZA , A CHARACTERISTIC FEATURE OF ZANDE LANGUAGE AND THOUGHT 1956

The *wene sanza*, good *sanza*, said as a pleasantry, is spoken in various situations where a direct statement would be impolite or shameful or not hit the mark so effectively. For one reason or another it is best to be circumlocutory. The *gbigbita sanza*, the bad *sanza*, is more common. One uses it because subterfuge is advisable—it is not merely that one wants to score a point and to hurt, one also dares not say openly what one wants to say because of the relationship involved, the wife to husband relationship, that of commoner to prince, that between blood-brothers, that of a man to his in-laws. etc. And even what passes for good *sanza* may be malicious by a sort of double inversion. With certain persons, particularly with blood-brothers, it is permissible to use a joking language, called *buga*, in which things may be said which would not be proper if said to other persons. Azande work off a lot of *sanza* under this cover. An insult to one's blood-brother is presented as a joke. He is not supposed to take it seriously, but he may in fact take the words to be intended to bear their overt meaning in the guise of a joke, and they may indeed be intended to carry this meaning. Or two blood-brothers may sling insults at one another knowing that there is a third man within earshot, the insults being intended for him. Men who frequent court are there to serve their own interests and in competition to win the favour of their prince, and they are well-known for their skill in getting in sharp, sly little digs at one another in the form of apparently innocuous jokes and  224 harmless small talk, and even in the form of compliments. A favourite way of doing this is to say the opposite of what is meant. The more the words are cloaked by expression of sincerity and friendship the more successful is this method of pricking the victim. Even if he does not see through them himself others may, so the effort is not wasted. Thus one says to a man who is, in one's opinion, talking nonsense 'oh sir, how well you know how to speak'. This sarcastic mode may also be employed discreetly with in-laws or in the home. For example, a wife says in *sanza* to another man's wife in the presence of her husband 'the renown of your home is greater than ours'. In fact, she means the opposite and is having a dig at the owner of the homestead who, she well knows, hears what she says. He understands the innuendo and asks 'what is the matter here, mistress?'. His wife replies in another *sanza* 'yes, sir, our home has a

 195
[Sociolinguistics](#)

 571
[Social Relationships
And Groups](#)

 578
[Ingroup Antagonisms](#)

 608
[Artificial Kin
Relationships](#)

great reputation; she was saying nice things about it, sir, that people say that you would not eat anything and leave your wives without it' (which is precisely what he does do).

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